MODULE 32 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

The Sequences the Exam Tests

One rule behind every process in the course, every sequence on a page per domain, the distractor patterns in ordering items, and eleven new ordering drills.

SCOPE All seven domains FOCUS Ordering items MODULE 32 of 38

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You write the answer key before you mark the papers. **Whatever defines "good" always comes first.**

The anchor rule: one shape behind every sequence

01
Define
Criteria, requirements, hypothesis, constraints, authority.

›

02
Measure
Today's state: a baseline.

›

03
Change
One thing at a time.

›

04
Verify
Against the definition, not a feeling.

›

05
Record
ADR, runbook, eval case.

ON THE EXAM

When unsure of an order, anchor on the step that defines good. It comes before anything that builds, measures or changes.

How ordering items are written

- **"Which two steps should come BEFORE X?"** The answers sit just before X.
- **"What should the architect do FIRST?"** Usually the defining step.
- **"What is the NEXT step?"** Name where you are, then take one step.
- **Distractor 1:** the right step at the wrong time, such as alerts before objectives.
- **Distractor 2:** a step that skips the definition, such as building before criteria.
- **Distractor 3:** a tool-first fix, such as a router before splitting an agent.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> In a BEFORE item, eliminate every option that belongs after X. What remains is usually the answer.

Design, models and context

SEQUENCE	ORDER
Framing a problem (m02)	Decision, user, today, measure, constraints, then shape
Comparing architectures (m06)	Constraints, SLA gate, quality floor, cost, value, recommend
Choosing a model (m07)	Define, shortlist, test, choose, route, re-test
Budgeting context (m09)	Measure, remove, order, cache, bound, monitor
Cacheable order (m10)	Tools, system, earlier messages, breakpoint, new input

THE TIEBREAKER

Constraints and definitions open every design sequence. Shape and choice come later.

Integration

SEQUENCE	ORDER
Fixing tool bloat (m11)	Inventory, remove, consolidate, split by domain, route and re-test
Designing context (m12)	Remove, measure, keep hot items, defer or retrieve, evaluate misses
Retrieval pipeline (m14)	Ingest and clean, chunk, enrich and embed, index, retrieve and rerank, generate
Security review (m15)	Map identities, trace access, find secrets, check records, walk the path
Justifying a configuration (m16)	Get it right, baseline, change one lever, re-measure, keep or revert

THE TIEBREAKER

Remove before you add. A router or a new mechanism comes last, never first.

Evaluation and optimisation

SEQUENCE	ORDER
Evaluation (m18)	Define, curate and label, run, score, review failures, gate release
Experiment (m19)	Hypothesis, metrics, power, randomise and run, decide, document
Diagnosis (m20)	What changed, reproduce, isolate the layer, compare, fix one thing, lock it in
Optimisation (m21)	Measure, zero-risk first, fewer tokens, route, batch, re-measure
Monitoring (m21)	SLOs, error budget, instrument, dashboards, alerts, runbooks

THE TIEBREAKER

Hypothesis and objectives before data. Data before decisions.

Governance and lifecycle

SEQUENCE	ORDER
Risk assessment (m22)	Scope, failure modes, rate, assign controls, test, monitor
Human review (m23)	Classify, place checkpoints, write criteria, set triggers, sample, adjust
Compliance (m24)	Map data, regimes and roles, platform, eligible features, design within, document
Discovery (m26)	Goals, today, requirements, criteria, risks, validate
Handoff (m29)	Package, walkthrough, shadow, reverse shadow, game day, sign-off

THE TIEBREAKER

Map the data before the platform. Agree criteria before validating. Prove the handoff before signing it off.

Communication and developer enablement

SEQUENCE	ORDER
Layered paper (m27)	Decision, why, options, trade-offs, the ask, appendices
Renegotiating (m28)	Detect early, quantify, explain, offer options, agree, record
Federated Skills (m30)	Author, propose, review, publish, restrict, install
Rollout (m31)	Value and authority, baseline, pilot, iterate, roll out, monitor
Debugging (m31)	Observe, hypothesise, reproduce, fix, verify, document

THE TIEBREAKER

Decision first on paper. Reproduce before fixing. Pilot before rolling out.

Where each sequence starts

SEQUENCE	STARTS WITH
Diagnosis	What changed?
Debugging	Observe the symptoms
Experiment	A hypothesis
Optimisation	Measure
Discovery	Goals
Compliance	Map the data
Tool bloat	Inventory

THE TIEBREAKER

Learn the first step of each sequence. Most FIRST items are answered by it.

> Tallyhawk wants to test a new reply prompt for the support agent against the current one.

What should the team do first?

A. Write the hypothesis, the primary metric and the threshold that would count as success

B. Split live traffic evenly between the two prompts, chosen at random

C. Run the comparison for a full week to cover weekday patterns

D. Calculate statistical power once enough results have come in

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the team do first?

A Write the hypothesis, the primary metric and the threshold that would count as success

Defines good before any data.

B Split live traffic evenly between the two prompts, chosen at random

Randomising comes after design.

C Run the comparison for a full week to cover weekday patterns

Running comes after design.

D Calculate statistical power once enough results have come in

Power is computed before the run.

THE SIGNAL

Hypothesis and metric define good. They come before traffic is touched.

> Quillon wants to move portal questions to a smaller model tier.
>
> The contract requires 92% on the evaluation set and first token within 2 seconds at p95.

Which two steps should come BEFORE switching production traffic? Choose two.

A Announce the switch date to patients on the portal

B Remove the current model from all configuration files

C Monitor portal complaints for a month after the switch

D Run the portal evaluation set on the smaller tier against both requirements

E Define the routing rule and the rollback plan, and record them in an ADR

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two steps should come BEFORE switching production traffic? Choose two.

A Announce the switch date to patients on the portal

Patients do not need it.

B Remove the current model from all configuration files

Removes the rollback path.

C Monitor portal complaints for a month after the switch

After the switch, not before.

D Run the portal evaluation set on the smaller tier against both requirements

Test against the requirements.

E Define the routing rule and the rollback plan, and record them in an ADR

Route, with a way back, recorded.

THE SIGNAL

Test against the requirements, then route with a rollback ready. Monitoring comes after.

> Tallyhawk's billing agent has grown to twenty-six tools, several with overlapping descriptions.
>
> Proposals include a router, tool search and splitting the agent.

What should the team do first?

A Put a router agent in front of the billing agent

B Inventory the tools, and remove or merge the unused and overlapping ones

C Turn on tool search so that tools load on demand

D Split the agent into separate invoicing and refunds agents

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the team do first?

A Put a router agent in front of the billing agent

Tool-first, and comes last.

B Inventory the tools, and remove or merge the unused and overlapping ones

Inventory and remove first.

C Turn on tool search so that tools load on demand

Defers the confusion, does not remove it.

D Split the agent into separate invoicing and refunds agents

Splitting comes after cleaning up.

THE SIGNAL

Remove before you add. Inventory and consolidate before splitting or routing.

> Mereside is adding human review to mortgage document extraction.
>
> The team is about to set the sampling rate for reviewing extracted fields.

Which two steps should come BEFORE setting the sampling rate? Choose two.

A Classify the extracted fields by risk and reversibility

B Measure reviewer agreement over the first month

C Write the criteria reviewers will apply to each field

D Tune the rate from production error data

E Announce the review process to brokers

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two steps should come BEFORE setting the sampling rate? Choose two.

A Classify the extracted fields by risk and reversibility

Classification comes first.

B Measure reviewer agreement over the first month

After launch.

C Write the criteria reviewers will apply to each field

Criteria before sampling.

D Tune the rate from production error data

After launch.

E Announce the review process to brokers

Not part of the design.

THE SIGNAL

Classify, place checkpoints, write criteria, set triggers, then sample.

> Quillon's goals for a patient billing-dispute assistant have just been agreed with the business owner.

What is the next discovery step?

A Build a prototype so that patients can try it early

B Set success criteria and failure thresholds for launch

C Map today's dispute process, its volumes and a baseline

D Choose the model tier and the deployment platform

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the next discovery step?

A Build a prototype so that patients can try it early

Validation comes last.

B Set success criteria and failure thresholds for launch

Comes after requirements.

C Map today's dispute process, its volumes and a baseline

Today comes straight after goals.

D Choose the model tier and the deployment platform

A design decision, not discovery.

THE SIGNAL

Goals, then today, then requirements, then criteria, then risks, then validate.

> Corvane is setting up production monitoring for Mereside's agent assist.
>
> The team wants to configure alerts this week.

Which two steps should come BEFORE configuring alerts? Choose two.

A Write runbooks for each alert

B Define service level objectives for latency and quality

C Choose the colour scheme for the dashboards

D Set the error budget that follows from those objectives

E Page on-call for every slow request

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two steps should come BEFORE configuring alerts? Choose two.

A Write runbooks for each alert

Runbooks follow the alerts.

B Define service level objectives for latency and quality

Objectives define good.

C Choose the colour scheme for the dashboards

Not a sequence step.

D Set the error budget that follows from those objectives

Budget comes from objectives.

E Page on-call for every slow request

Noise, not monitoring.

THE SIGNAL

Objectives and error budget before instruments and alerts.

> Tallyhawk plans to let its support agent handle accounts for EU customers.
>
> The engineering lead wants to pick the deployment platform first.

What should come first?

A Choose the platform that offers EU processing

B Check which features are eligible on that platform

C Draft the data processing agreement

D Map what personal data flows where, and for which purposes

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should come first?

A Choose the platform that offers EU processing

Platform comes after regimes.

B Check which features are eligible on that platform

Eligibility follows the platform.

C Draft the data processing agreement

Contract follows the mapping.

D Map what personal data flows where, and for which purposes

Map the data first.

THE SIGNAL

Map the data, then the regimes and roles, then the platform and its eligible features.

> Quillon's clinical informatics team will take over the prior-authorisation system.
>
> Both sides want to sign off the handoff next month.

Which two steps should come BEFORE sign-off? Choose two.

A Hold the first quarterly steering review

B A reverse shadow, where Quillon's team operates while Corvane watches

C Retire the evaluation set, since the build is complete

D Move operation permanently to Corvane's run service

E A game day, where Quillon's team handles a staged incident from the runbooks

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two steps should come BEFORE sign-off? Choose two.

A Hold the first quarterly steering review

A later lifecycle event.

B A reverse shadow, where Quillon's team operates while Corvane watches

Proves they can operate it.

C Retire the evaluation set, since the build is complete

The set carries forward.

D Move operation permanently to Corvane's run service

The opposite of a handoff.

E A game day, where Quillon's team handles a staged incident from the runbooks

Proves the runbooks work.

THE SIGNAL

Prove the handoff before signing it off: reverse shadow, then game day.

> Corvane has two candidate designs for Mereside's agent assist.
>
> Both look promising, and the sponsor wants a recommendation.

What should Corvane do first?

A Compare the cost per call of the two designs

B Score each design on expected business value

C Check both against the hard constraints and the latency SLA, and strike any that fail

D Pick whichever design is cheaper among those above the quality floor

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should Corvane do first?

A Compare the cost per call of the two designs

Cost comes after the gates.

B Score each design on expected business value

Value comes after cost.

C Check both against the hard constraints and the latency SLA, and strike any that fail

Constraints and SLA gate first.

D Pick whichever design is cheaper among those above the quality floor

Skips the constraint and SLA gates.

THE SIGNAL

Eliminate on constraints and the SLA gate, then weigh quality, cost and value.

> Tallyhawk is reordering its support agent's prompt to get more cache hits.
>
> The prompt has tool definitions, a long system prompt, the customer's new question, and earlier turns.

Which component should come first in the request?

A The customer's new question, so it gets the most attention

B The tool definitions, which are identical on every request

C The earlier turns of the conversation

D A timestamp, so every request is clearly dated

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which component should come first in the request?

A The customer's new question, so it gets the most attention

New input comes last.

B The tool definitions, which are identical on every request

Stable content first.

C The earlier turns of the conversation

After tools and system.

D A timestamp, so every request is clearly dated

Breaks the cache for everything after it.

THE SIGNAL

For caching, stable first: tools, system, earlier messages, breakpoint, then new input.

> Quillon's portal is missing its latency SLA after a new feature.
>
> Corvane must agree a revised target with Quillon.

Which two steps should come BEFORE agreeing the revised target? Choose two.

A Quantify the gap with measured data

B Record the new target in the SLA and the ADR

C Quietly change how latency is measured

D Explain the cause, and offer options

E Sign the revised contract

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two steps should come BEFORE agreeing the revised target? Choose two.

A Quantify the gap with measured data
Measured gap first.

B Record the new target in the SLA and the ADR
After agreement.

C Quietly change how latency is measured
Hides the gap.

D Explain the cause, and offer options
Cause and options before agreeing.

E Sign the revised contract
That is the agreement itself.

THE SIGNAL

Detect, quantify, explain, offer options, then agree and record.

In five lines

- **Anchor rule:** define, measure, change, verify, record.
- **BEFORE items:** eliminate everything that belongs after X.
- **FIRST items:** usually the step that defines good.
- **Distractors:** right step at the wrong time, skipped definition, tool first.
- **Remove before you add;** map before you choose; reproduce before you fix.

> COMING UP
>
> Next: confusion pairs, side by side.